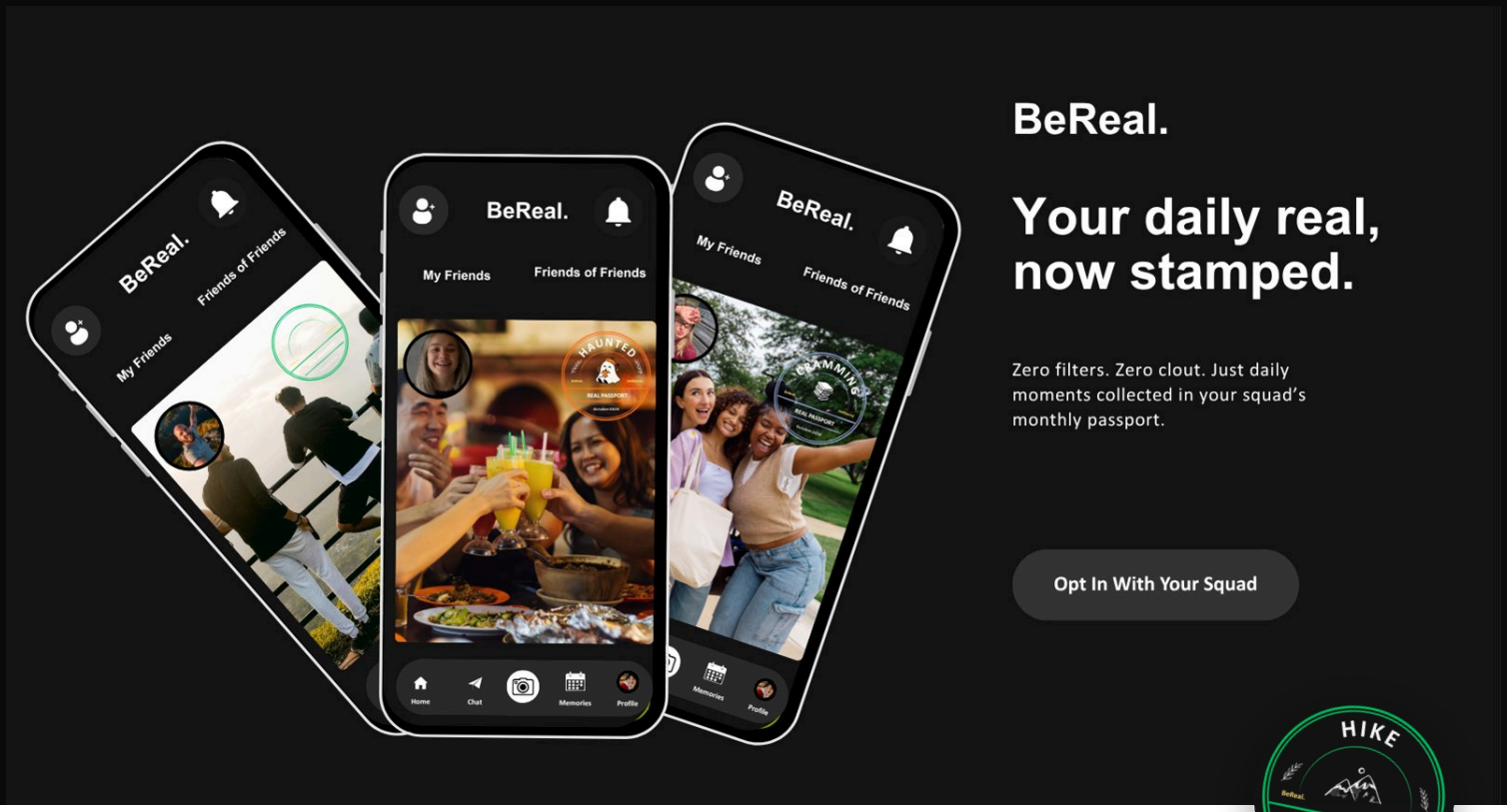
WHITE PAPER · OCTOBER 2026

BeReal.





The Real Process: Designing, Testing and Pitching a Product Feature in an 8-Week Externship

An end-to-end account of BeReal Passport & Community Boards, a re-engagement concept for casual BeReal users, from research and UI/UX design through AI-assisted prototyping, user testing, requirements and strategy.

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BeReal Product Management Externship with Extern
August – October 2026

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

A tested feature, built the way real product teams work

BeReal won attention with one simple rule: one unfiltered photo a day. Keeping that attention has been harder. Daily users fell from about 15 million to about 6 million in a matter of months. During the BeReal Product Management Externship with Extern, I took on that problem as both the UI/UX designer and the product manager. This paper documents the full process, the deliverables it produced and what I would tell anyone starting a similar externship.

The result is **BeReal Passport & Community Boards**: small squads share monthly themed boards, each post earns a collectible *Real Passport* stamp, and each month is saved as a keepsake capsule. It is opt-in, uses the same real dual-camera photo and has no public likes, so it adds a second reason to open the app without adding the pressure BeReal was built against.

4 of 5
focus-group testers would open BeReal more often

4.2 / 5
reminders and streak felt low-pressure, the highest score

3 · 1 · 1
would launch it: yes · maybe · no

20+
deliverables, from teardown to technical design

KEY FINDINGS

1. **The risk was complexity, not pressure.** Testers liked the low-pressure design; the main friction was too many taps from capture to stamp.
2. **Evidence should change the plan.** Testing reshaped the requirements (PRD v1.0 → v2.0), the rollout and the test plan.
3. **Design the spec first, then prompt.** A detailed Canva design deck let AI produce a working, testable prototype from a single prompt.
4. **Small tests show direction, not proof.** Five testers justify a refined retest and a controlled A/B experiment, not a launch.

Contents

1 Introduction
2 The problem
3 Methodology
4 Discovery and research
5 Solution design (UI/UX)
6 AI-assisted prototyping
7 Validation
8 From evidence to requirements
9 Strategy and scale
10 Enablement and storytelling
11 Deliverables inventory
12 Lessons and recommendations
13 Conclusion
— Sources and links

1 Introduction

Externships are short, project-based programs that let professionals practice a role on a realistic brief. The BeReal Product Management Externship with Extern asked participants to work through the core activities of a product manager over eight weeks: mapping the user journey, benchmarking competitors, designing and prototyping a feature, testing it with real users and pitching a recommendation to leadership.

I came to the externship as a Technical Product Manager. A strong grasp of technical delivery and business strategy is an advantage in product work, but UI/UX skills close the loop. They make it possible to balance what is viable for the business, feasible to build and right for the user. I worked solo, so I held both roles: **UI/UX designer** and **product manager**.

This paper follows the project in order. Each section explains what I did, why, and which deliverable came out of it. I named the portfolio **BeReal-RealProcess** because, in the spirit of BeReal, it shows the real process: the drafts as well as the final versions, the friction testing uncovered, and the honest limits of the evidence.

> **NOTE**
> BeReal Passport & Community Boards is an independent concept created for a UI/UX Design & Product Management Externship. It is not affiliated with or endorsed by BeReal.

2 The problem

BeReal's core idea, one unfiltered photo a day at a random time, made it stand out. Its growth was fast: 73.5 million monthly active users in August 2022. Its decline was fast too. Daily users fell about 61%, from roughly 15 million in October 2022 to under 6 million in March 2023, according to Apptopia data reported by The New York Times. Competitors copied the format within months: Instagram added Dual Camera and Candid Stories, and TikTok launched TikTok Now.

For casual users, BeReal asks for effort every day and offers little reason to come back once the novelty fades. The app gives one reason to open it per day, and that reason can feel like pressure.

> **THE QUESTION**
> How might we give casual users a reason to return to BeReal, without breaking what makes BeReal *real*?

3 Methodology

I followed the product development life cycle (PDLC), extended with three phases that went beyond the required deliverables: enabling users, planning validation and technical design. Each phase produced at least one artifact, and each artifact fed the next.



When	Phase	What I did
Aug 2026	**1. Discover**	UI/UX teardown of the current app, company snapshot, and benchmarking of TikTok's and BeReal's retention features
Aug 2026	**2. Define**	Persona "Denise," a five-stage journey map, flow diagram and storyboard
Sep 2026	**3. Design**	Seven-screen user flow, UI states and re-engagement hooks in a Canva spec deck; PRD v1.0 drafted before testing
Oct 2026	**4. Prototype & test**	Clickable prototype built with Claude; focus group on October 20 (5 participants, 3 tasks, think-aloud plus survey)
Oct 24–26	**5. Pitch**	Test summary, 5-minute pitch deck and video, 16-minute case study deck and video, promo reel
Oct 27	**6. Revise requirements**	PRD v2.0 with test results and a re-phased rollout: refine, then retest
Oct 27	**7–9. Beyond the brief**	Interactive job aid, competitive analysis, feature working session, A/B test plan and technical design

August and September milestones are shown by month. Dates from October 20 onward come from the case study and the repository's commit history.

4 Discovery and research

4.1 Teardown and benchmarking

I started with a UI/UX teardown of BeReal as it is today, then benchmarked how the two most relevant apps keep people coming back. TikTok wins with discovery and gamification: an endless For You feed, Duets and Stitch, and hashtag challenges with streaks. BeReal's loop runs on friends and reciprocity: a random daily alert, a locked feed until you post, and RealMoji reactions. The gap was clear. BeReal has a trusted, authentic format and a friend graph, but only **one reason a day** to open the app.

Mechanic	Seen in	Decision	How it shows up in the concept
Themed challenges	TikTok	**Adapt**	Monthly themed boards: HIKE, CRAMMING, COFFEE, HAUNTED
Progression badges	TikTok, Snapchat	**Adapt**	Collectible Real Passport stamps, with no loss framing
Streaks	Snapchat, TikTok	**Soften**	"You've been real 3 days in a row," with no streak to lose
Post to see	BeReal	**Keep**	Squad posts stay blurred until you post
Weekly recap	Locket	**Adapt**	A monthly capsule saved to Memories
Endless feed, public likes	TikTok, Instagram	**Avoid**	Boards close each month; no public metrics anywhere

4.2 Persona and journey

The primary persona, **Denise**, is an introverted first-time user who prefers low-pressure interactions, values privacy and feels friction with forced real-time sharing. Mapping her through five stages of the current app showed where the experience pushes her away:

Stage	What Denise feels	Friction
1. Onboard	Curious but cautious	Phone number and notifications feel like a lot up front
2. Connect	Selective, protective of privacy	Contact-sync prompts push for a wider circle than she wants
3. Prompt	Stressed, put on the spot	The 2-minute timer adds performance anxiety
4. Capture	Self-conscious, exposed	No control over the photo; the "Late" label feels like public judgment
5. Consume	Relieved, a passive observer	The feed is locked until she posts

From this research I set four guardrails that every later decision had to respect: **authentic, opt-in, low pressure and friends-only**.

5 Solution design (UI/UX)

The design goal in one line: **add a new reason to open BeReal without making it feel like a different app.** Every new element had to look and behave as if it already belonged in BeReal.

5.1 The concept

- **Squads:** small, chosen groups instead of a wide friend list.
- **Monthly themed boards:** a shared prompt the squad posts to on their own time, with no countdown.

- **Real Passport stamps:** each board post earns a collectible stamp.
- **Monthly capsules:** each board closes into a keepsake in Memories.

The flow keeps capture as fast as it is today. Users take their BeReal as usual, then choose **SEND** (a regular post) or **COMMUNITY BOARD** (a themed post plus a stamp). The board choice comes *after* the photo, as a layer on top.

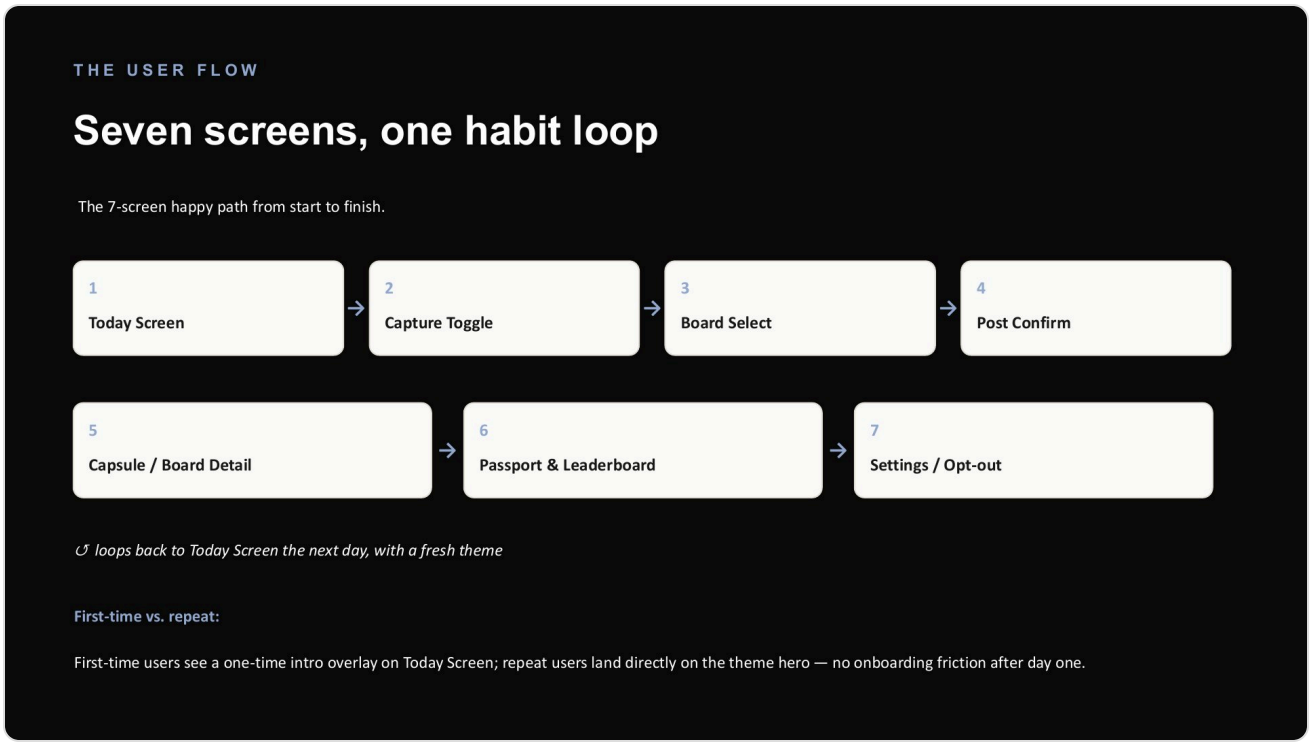


Figure 1. The seven-screen habit loop, designed in Canva: Today, Capture toggle, Board select, Post confirm, Capsule, Passport & Leaderboard, and Settings / Opt-out.

5.2 Design principles and system

Before designing any screen, I set five visual principles: a **pitch-black canvas**, a **candid dual-camera feel**, **tactile pastel stamp ink**, **private squad reactions** and a **monthly collection loop**. The design system borrowed BeReal's look token by token: a near-black canvas (#0A0A0A), grey surfaces (#2C2C2C), white text and a single yellow accent (#FFDE59) reserved for one call to action per screen. Each board has its own stamp ink.

UX principle	Where it shows up
Jakob's law	Top bar, Friends tabs and bottom navigation kept exactly as in BeReal
Hick's law	After the photo, only two choices: SEND or COMMUNITY BOARD
Visibility of system status	Every post shows loading, success or error, plus an empty state
Progressive disclosure	A one-time intro for new users; returning users go straight to the board snapshot
Emotional design	Copy invites rather than pressures: "No one's posted to this board yet — be the first!"

Accessibility. White on the canvas has a 19.8:1 contrast ratio, yellow on the canvas 14.9:1 and white on grey 14.0:1, all passing WCAG AA and AAA for normal text. Color is never the only signal: a selected board also changes its label and lock icon.

What I deliberately left out: an algorithmic feed, public leaderboards, loss-framed streaks and filters. Each would raise engagement on paper while breaking what makes BeReal BeReal.

5.3 Building it in Canva

I designed every screen in Canva as a high-fidelity, slide-by-slide prototype: seven screens, four UI states and three re-engagement hooks (a reminder bubble, a soft streak cue and a come-back banner). Each slide used a rounded-rectangle phone frame with layered screen content, annotations explaining the user's action and the reasoning, and arrows connecting each "before" screen to its "after." Reusable components (top bar, tabs, navigation, board tiles, stamps and modals) were built once and duplicated, so every screen stayed consistent.

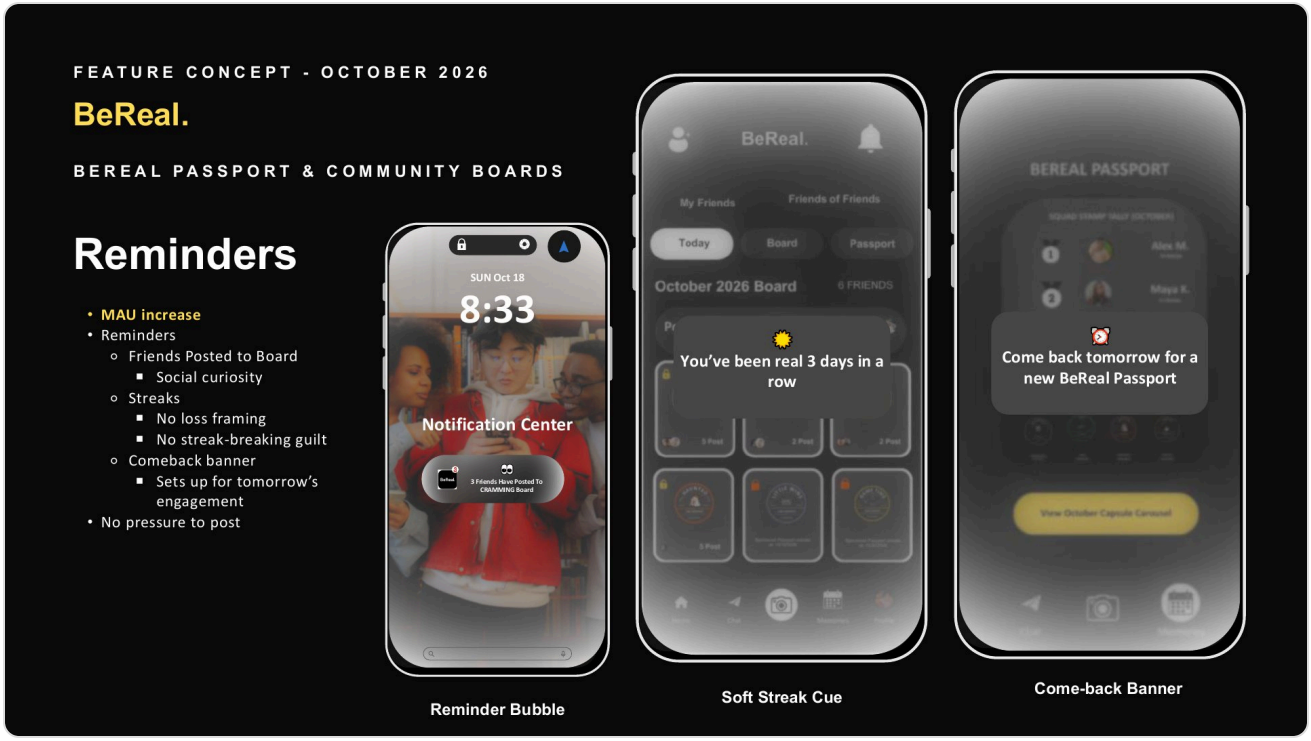


Figure 2. A Canva spec slide for the re-engagement hooks: reminder bubble, soft streak cue and come-back banner, each annotated with the reasoning.

6 AI-assisted prototyping

Static slides can't be tested the way a real app can, so the Canva deck became the **specification** for a clickable prototype. I gave the deck to Claude with one prompt:

> **THE PROMPT**
>
> "As a developer and product manager, I would like to create a prototype for my proposed BeReal enhancement, BeReal Passport & Community Boards. I have a presentation showing how the user flow and enhancements should look."

The result was a clickable HTML prototype of the full seven-screen flow, including the empty, loading, success and error states from the deck, and a demo panel for switching between first-time and returning users. Because the design decisions were already made and annotated, the prompt could stay short: the deck carried the detail.

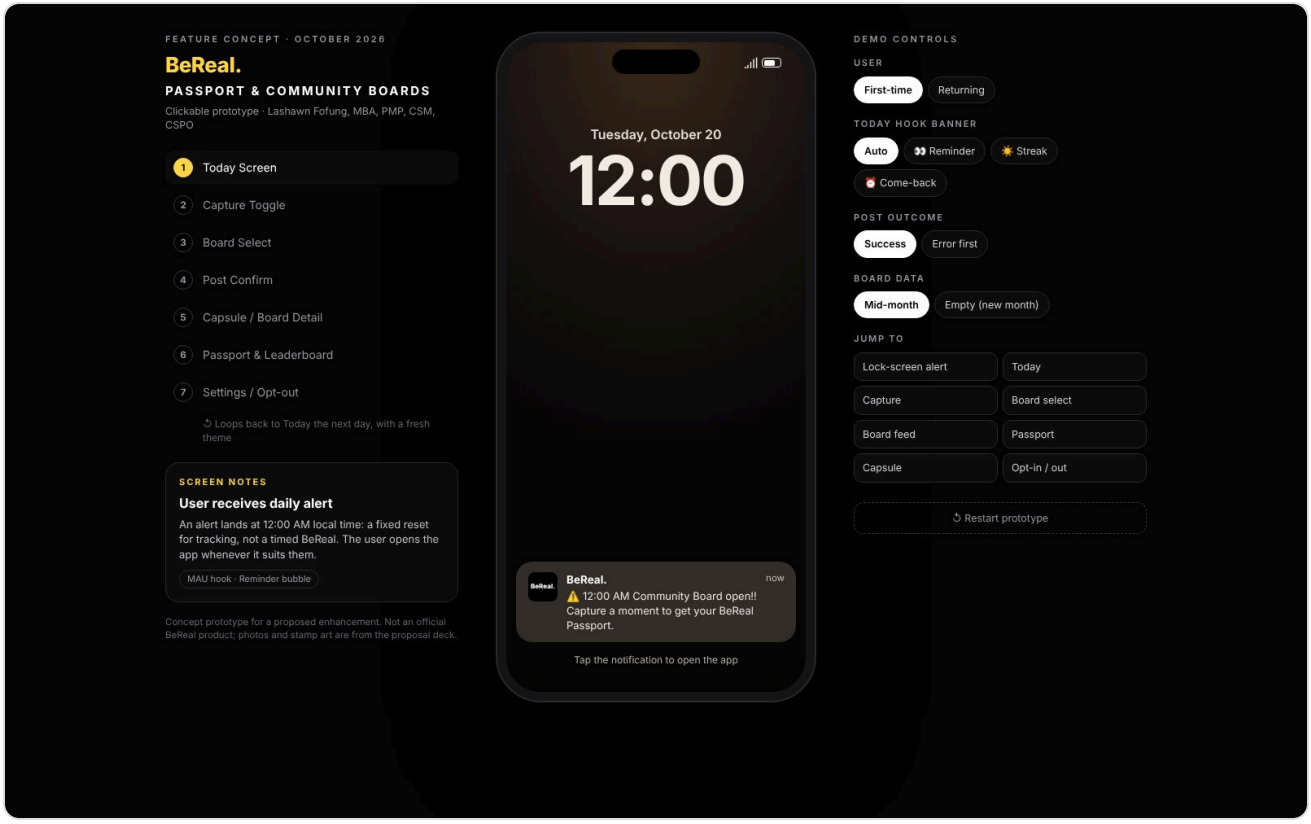


Figure 3. The clickable prototype, with the flow on the left, the phone in the center and demo controls on the right. Try it live.

Hosting on GitHub Pages

To make the prototype viewable in any browser with no login, I hosted it on GitHub Pages. Three problems taught me how the platform works:

Problem	Fix
The site showed only the README	Added an `index.html` at the repository root that redirects to the prototype
The homepage returned a 404	The file was named `Index.html`; GitHub Pages is case-sensitive, so I renamed it
The Save button was greyed out	Switched the branch to None, saved, then switched back to main to trigger a fresh deploy

7 Validation

On October 20, I ran a 40-minute, in-person focus group with five participants: one daily, two occasional and two rare BeReal users. Each completed three tasks in the clickable prototype while thinking aloud, then answered an eight-question survey.

Survey item (average score out of 5)	Score
Easy to understand	3.6
Feels authentic to BeReal	3.6
Would open BeReal more often	3.8
Reminders and streak felt low-pressure	**4.2** (highest)

What worked. Four of five testers said they would open BeReal more often, and both occasional users rated "open BeReal more often" a perfect 5. One put it simply: "*I'd definitely open the app more often because of this.*"

The honest gap. Testers noticed "a few too many button clicks" between capture and stamp, and the one non-user called the flow "less authentic and overly complex." The biggest risk was **complexity, not pressure**.

> **CAVEAT**
>
> Five testers is enough to find usability problems and gauge direction, but not enough to predict behavior at scale. These results are an early signal, not proof. That is why the recommendation was to refine and retest, not to launch.

8 From evidence to requirements

A product requirements document (PRD) is a living document: it gets a new version whenever new evidence changes what we would build. I wrote two formats, a **PRD-lite 1-pager** for busy reviewers and a **full requirements document** for product, design and engineering teams, and versioned both.

PRD v1.0 (September 2026) was a draft written before testing, from research and early design. **PRD v2.0** (October 27, 2026) aligned the requirements to the tested prototype and the evidence:

Area	v1.0	v2.0
Post types	"Theme Post / Random Post" toggle at capture	SEND or COMMUNITY BOARD, chosen *after* the photo so capture stays fast
Social	Hearts, votes and comments	Squad-only emoji reactions; no public like counts
Leaderboard	+10 points per post	Squad Stamp Tally, ranked by stamps collected
Target user	Socially active users; three personas	Denise, plus casual and drifting users
Metrics	DAU/MAU, daily opens, retention, adoption	Adds taps and time from capture to stamp, and a 2.5× daily-opens target
Risks	Four risks	Adds complexity (too many taps), with mitigations from testing
Rollout	Prototype → MVP → expand → sponsors	Prototype & test (done) → **refine & retest** (7–10 people) → MVP → full rollout → sponsored pilot
The ask	Approve an MVP test	Approve the refine-and-retest round before committing to the MVP

The recommendation: refine, then retest

1. **Cut taps from capture to stamp**, for example by remembering the last board used.
2. **Make SEND vs. COMMUNITY BOARD clear**, with a one-line explainer on first use.
3. **Add a first-use walkthrough**, tested with people who don't use BeReal today.

9 Strategy and scale

After the required deliverables, I wrote three strategy documents to show how the concept would hold up in a real product organization.

9.1 Competitive analysis and defensibility

The close-friends, low-pressure space is the least crowded in social media. Locket owns quiet presence there but offers no shared occasion and no progression. The feature itself can be copied, as Instagram showed with BeReal's camera format. Defensibility comes from what surrounds it: **brand fit** (no public likes conflicts with ad-driven models), **switching costs that grow** (stamps and capsules accumulate), **small-group network effects** and a **monthly operating cadence** of new themes.

9.2 A two-stage test plan

The test plan answers one decision: **ship, iterate or kill.** Stage 1 is a moderated usability retest with 7–10 people to confirm the redesign fixed the friction. Stage 2 is a squad-randomized A/B experiment for the MVP.

Element	Definition
Primary metric	Active days per casual user (days with at least one app open in a 28-day window), chosen in advance
Guardrails	Metrics that must not get worse, such as regular (non-board) posting
Ship	Primary metric lifts ≥ +5% for casual users (statistically significant) and no guardrail is breached
Iterate	Positive but not significant, opt-in below 15%, or a guardrail close to its threshold
Kill	Upper confidence bound below +2%, or any guardrail breached (e.g., regular posts drop more than 2%)

9.3 Technical design

The technical design shows how the feature could be built on top of BeReal's existing systems with as little as possible added. The core idea: **a board post is a tag on an existing BeReal post, not a new kind of content.** It covers the data model, a 12:00 AM local-time unlock scheduled by UTC offset (fewer than 40 jobs a night instead of millions), a Squad Stamp Tally computed with write-time counters and nightly reconciliation, and squad-only privacy enforced on the server for every read.

10 Enablement and storytelling

10.1 The interactive job aid

A new feature only works if people can use it on their first try. Since testing showed complexity was the biggest risk, I built an interactive job aid from real prototype screens: users tap the highlighted button on each screen to move through the flow, just as they would on their phone. I built it with Claude in three short prompts, each building on the last:

1. "Create a job aid for the application."
2. "I want the job aid to be HTML."
3. "Can you make the job aid similar to the app workflow, as the user clicks on buttons and pages?"

Then I had Claude write one detailed, reusable prompt that recreates the job aid in a single pass, plus a step-list spreadsheet template, so the next job aid is a fill-in-the-rows task.

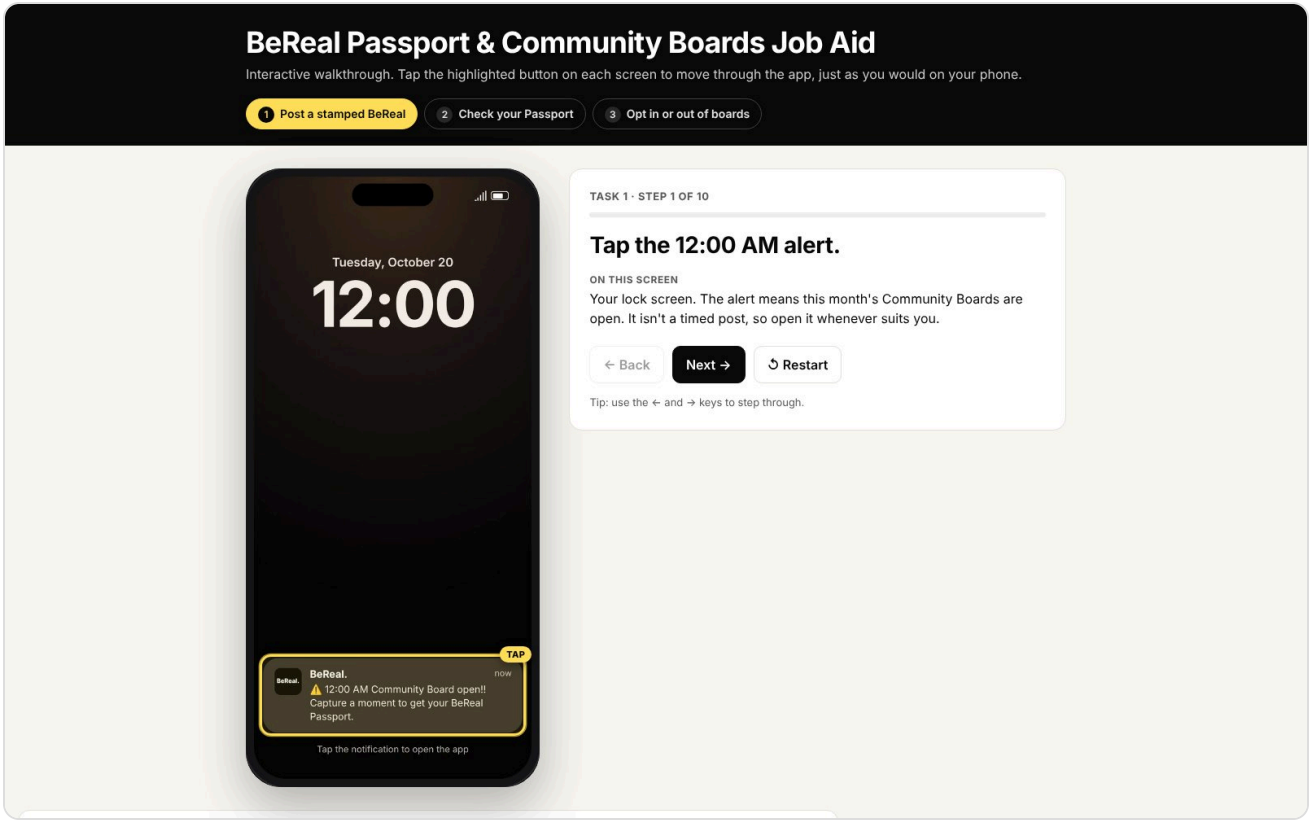


Figure 4. The interactive job aid: three tasks, step-by-step guidance and real prototype screens. Try it.

10.2 Pitch, case study and promotion

I told the story in formats for different audiences: a **5-minute pitch** to leadership, a **16-minute case study** walking through all four parts of the work, a vertical **promo reel** with my own voiceover, and social videos and posts for LinkedIn and YouTube. Each one led with the same message: the problem, the evidence, the honest gap and the recommendation.

11 Deliverables inventory

Deliverable	Phase	Purpose
UI/UX teardown & company snapshot	Discover	Baseline of the current app and business
Competitor benchmarking & competitive analysis	Discover / Strategy	Retention mechanics to borrow, adapt or avoid; positioning and moats
Persona & journey map, flow diagram, storyboard	Define	Who the feature is for and where today's experience loses her
Canva spec deck	Design	Seven screens, four UI states and three re-engagement hooks
UI/UX design document	Design	Principles, design system, accessibility and brand fidelity, element by element
Clickable prototype	Prototype & test	A testable, shareable version of the full flow
Focus group plan, guide, survey & report	Prototype & test	Evidence for the recommendation
Pitch deck & video (5 min)	Pitch	The recommendation for leadership
Case study deck & video (16 min)	Pitch	The full story, part by part
PRD v1.0 → v2.0 (1-pager and full)	Revise requirements	Requirements versioned by evidence
Interactive job aid, step list & reusable prompt	Enable users	First-use success, and a repeatable process
Feature working session	Strategy	How competitor mechanics became features
A/B test plan	Plan validation	Ship, iterate or kill criteria
Technical design	Technical design	Data model, scheduling, tally and privacy
Project timeline	All	How the work and the plan evolved
Prompt engineering docs	All	How AI was used for the prototype and job aid
Promo reel, videos & social posts	Storytelling	Sharing the work with a wider audience

12 Lessons and recommendations

What I learned

1. **Guardrails make decisions faster.** Setting "authentic, opt-in, low pressure, friends-only" early made it easy to say no to ideas that would have boosted engagement on paper.
2. **Test the riskiest assumption, and listen when it's not the one you expected.** I designed against pressure; testing showed complexity was the real risk.
3. **Version your requirements.** Keeping PRD v1.0 next to v2.0 shows how evidence changed the plan, which is more convincing than a single polished document.
4. **Design the spec first, then prompt.** The quality of an AI-built prototype depends on the quality of the design you give it.
5. **Real screens beat redrawn ones.** Capturing the job aid from the prototype kept it accurate, and it can be recaptured whenever the design changes.
6. **Iterate the prompt, then save it.** Short prompts are good for exploring; one detailed, saved prompt makes the work repeatable.
7. **Be honest about the evidence.** Saying "five testers show direction, not proof" builds more trust than overclaiming.

Recommendations for future externs

- **Go one step past the brief.** A test plan, a technical design or a job aid shows how you would work on a real team.
- **Document the process, not just the outcome.** Hiring managers want to see how you think, including what changed and why.
- **Use the tools you have.** Canva had every element I needed for a high-fidelity prototype; AI turned it into something testable.
- **Publish everything in one place.** A single repository with a clear README makes the work easy to review and share.

13 Conclusion

In eight weeks, the BeReal Product Management Externship took one question (how to bring casual users back without breaking what makes BeReal real) through the full product development life cycle: research, design, an AI-assisted prototype, user testing, a pitch, revised requirements and a plan to validate at scale. The concept showed a promising signal, with four of five testers saying they would open BeReal more often, and an honest gap that sets the next step: **refine, then retest**.

Just as important as the feature is the process. Working as both designer and product manager, with AI as a collaborator, showed me how much one person can move from idea to evidence when every artifact feeds the next. That is the real process this project set out to document.



ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Lashawn Fofung, MBA, PMP, CSM, CSPO is a Technical Product Manager who completed the BeReal Product Management Externship with Extern as a UI/UX designer and product manager. She focuses on balancing what is viable for the business, feasible to build and right for the user. LinkedIn · Portfolio repository

Sources and links

Project

Portfolio repository: github.com/LashawnFofung/BeReal-RealProcess
Clickable prototype: lashawnfofung.github.io/BeReal-RealProcess
Interactive job aid: Job aid on GitHub Pages
Case study video (16 min): youtu.be/yxYclJn8ZGc · Pitch video (5 min): youtu.be/Or5O1wUj_Ow
PRD process and changes: PRD/PRD.md · Test plan: Test Plan · Technical design: Technical Design

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Independent concept created for a UI/UX Design & Product Management Externship. Not affiliated with or endorsed by BeReal. Stamp art and photos are from the project's proposal deck.